Session 13

2025-06-01

1 - The diamond, at last

~10:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru comes back to the gnome's jeweller's shop wearing a fresh elf face — a different one from the last encounter. The shop is spotless: no scorch marks, no sign that anything trapped or fired at all — the gnome tells him someone tried to rob him earlier and things had gotten worrying, but he heard noise while he was locked up and doesn't know what happened.
2. Amidamaru asks for a fifty-gold diamond, specifically for a spell. The gnome checks his stock — his price ledger wasn't laid out for every value, but a fifty-gold diamond can be produced.
3. Amidamaru pockets the diamond and heads back to the tavern.

2 - In the cells

~10:30, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Nuberroca, Nyx and Eguzkilore are held in adjacent, poorly-lit cells; their weapons and armour have been taken and only their clothes are left on them. In one nearby cell the tied-up bandit from the street fight lies silent — unconscious, asleep or simply mute, they can't tell. From another cell, someone else is present without speaking, only making small sounds.
2. Nuberroca calls across to Nyx to check on her, then asks whether they should be here at all, offering to leave. Nyx pushes back — this is his first city and cities have rules; you can't roam killing people on the street. Nuberroca insists he *has* adapted: bandits came with knives and weapons, so he adapted; the sergeant who took their weapons was not killed, was he? Nyx concedes he has restraint, and thanks him for not killing the guard.
3. Nuberroca says he's beginning to grow impatient; he doesn't like being shut in without a way out.
4. Nuberroca goes back to first principles for Nyx: his tribe's mandate is to help the weak and stamp out evil, and there was evil in this city — he cannot simply ignore it because the party would prefer he did. Nyx concedes the mandate but reframes it — evil can also be cleared from a place by pulling it off the streets and locking it up, not only by killing it. Yes, Nuberroca allows, with a rifle-butt to the head; Nyx sighs and asks him for a softer one next time.
5. From the cell opposite, a cracked old voice half-laughs at the two of them talking about clearing evil from the streets. Nuberroca calls across — who dares laugh?. The old man answers that *he* is here for denouncing exactly that — that the evil was never eradicated from the city, and the man who thinks he knows evil doesn't know what evil is in *this* city. Elturel, he says, was plagued and ruled by vampires until the second sun appeared — the gift of **Amaunator**, the sun-god, to be rid of them. He has been in this cell for years for saying that aloud.
6. Nyx pushes for detail: how long ago? Forty-seven years since **the Companion** appeared, five since he was jailed. Nuberroca asks who put him here — the Order of the Companion, together with the Order of the Hellriders, who have run the city since a few years after the Companion arose. The old man's charge is *religious heresy*: it is illegal to attribute the Companion — the light of Elturel — to any specific god, and he has been saying aloud that it was **Amaunator** who made it.
7. A guard appears at the bars, raps the metal for silence, tells them to keep the noise down, and walks off. The old voice fades to a quiet mutter; Nuberroca gives up on him and starts pacing.
8. Nyx checks on the bandit next door; Nuberroca reminds her it's the one who was still conscious and had confessed the kidnap plan on the walk over — the other, more badly wounded one, has since died of his wounds. The confessed bandit responds barely — *yes* — that the dead man was his friend; when Nyx offers condolence with a note about her friend being pressed to fight, he answers he owes them nothing. Nuberroca growls across at him — calling him a vile rat, he can start earning their way out of here — and the bandit refuses.
9. Hours later Nyx tells Nuberroca to be patient — they'll be judged or told what's happening, and no one is going to leave them here forever.

3 – The tavern reunion

~12:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Around midday Amidamaru walks into the common room of *A Pair of Black Antlers* wearing the elf face and greets Mialee and Sinsong as if nothing were different. Neither recognises him at first: Mialee reaches out with a small casting of her own and reads illusion-school magic layered over him.
2. Mialee runs the check she trusts most: reaches around behind him — under the elf outline — and taps shell. Amidamaru drops the disguise-check act; the party accepts he is Amidamaru.
3. Amidamaru delivers the news: Nuberroca lost his temper in the market, killed one bandit and knocked another unconscious, and the guards took him and the others away. Sinsong groans that he can't even get three days' rest — he can't sit through a cup of milk without it turning into another mess.
4. Amidamaru waves Sinsong off — let the grown-ups talk — and turns to Mialee: they will need her to get the others out.
5. Mialee corners Amidamaru with the practical question: where were the others taken? Amidamaru says he doesn't know, because he kept his distance so he could get back and tell them.

4 – Ontharr intercedes

~13:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The three cross to **Ontharr** at the back of the tavern. He is already unhappy that they are still in Elturel and hears the news with visible irritation — the party's own comrade has killed a man in the market. He tells them plainly that killing here is not looked on well; multiple killings warrant execution, and single ones are answered with fines, jails and exile. He walks off at once to speak with the tavern-keeper — every word audible across the room, no attempt to whisper — to arrange another river-barge out of the city for the following midday, because time is the party's real enemy.
2. Amidamaru slips to the privy first, refreshes the elf disguise so he stays the same face people saw on the street, and rejoins the others; he can stand witness for the hour the spell lasts. Ontharr has already told them the prisoners will be at the fortress of the Order of the Companion — that's where the city holds criminals.
3. Twenty minutes later they walk to a heavily fortified compound. Its banner carries a circle with a smaller sun-and-rays at the upper-left — the same emblem worn by the city watch and by a good number of knights across the streets, in two different sets of livery: two orders sharing one sigil.
4. At the gate Ontharr kneels to the door-guards in a gesture of respect and asks — in a level, almost honeyed voice — for audience over a killing committed that morning. The guards' faces are enough of an answer: they know exactly which killing he means, they discuss it briefly among themselves, and one steps inside.
5. Four or five minutes later a large armoured captain in the same two-suns emblem on his breastplate comes out and introduces himself as **Recaredo**. He recognises Ontharr from an earlier occasion and greets him with a small barb — *the murderer is one of yours, isn't he — I thought your order had better standards*. Ontharr only nods and hands the meeting over to the party. Sinsong takes the moment to sweep the captain for aberrations, celestials, elementals, fey, fiends and undead — nothing of those shows; the only magical thing he catches is Amidamaru's own illusion, which he already knew.
6. Amidamaru speaks first and at length. He tells the captain there were nearly ten bandits circling a small group of shoppers; they showed weapons on their belts and pressed in aggressively. Nuberroca, unused to a city's manners, reacted from fear — one bandit died, the second was captured — and no one was killed for killing's sake. When the captain replies that the witnesses have described the party striking first, Amidamaru pivots to a *psychological attack* — that fear of visible weapons and being circled by eight men is the true first blow. He closes with an appeal to necessity: the party is heading west to hunt dragons and needs Nuberroca back for that fight — take his return to the road as the goliath's penance.
7. The captain looks over at Ontharr, who gives a small honest nod that the story is true. He says he understands, turns without another word, and goes back inside.

5 - Recaredo's lesson

1. Deep in the cell block the same captain who had come out to Ontharr descends with a torch and two guards. The torchlight catches the old man's face — a small, thin, obviously old man — and he shrinks back into a corner and curls up on the ground.
2. Recaredo steps up to Nuberroca's cell: your companions have come to intercede, you're being released shortly. Before that, he says, a lesson.
3. Nyx shakes the bars and shouts, *what are you doing?*, uselessly. The three of them — Recaredo and the two guards — set on Nuberroca all at once with bare fists and pommels. There is no metal in the beating; the blows do not draw blood; they simply do not stop.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Recaredo draws his own greatsword last and lands a blow on Nuberroca, the goliath goes down, but remains with a thread of life. The knights hand him to his feet, and give him a pair of slaps for good measure. The captain's line as he pulls Nuberroca upright is that there are ways to bring an enemy down without killing him — learn non-lethal damage.
5. He then opens Nyx's cell and Eguzkilore's; on the bandits, he says, they will stand judgement, but the penalty for theft is not death — stealing does not justify killing.
6. Nyx crosses to Nuberroca and props him up so he can move his legs; she takes a hard look at all three of the men who beat him, wanting to keep the faces.

6 - Release

1. The party is walked to a storage room to collect their gear. Nuberroca re-armours himself as he goes and turns back to the captain — *I will not forget this lesson. What is your name?*.
2. The captain answers: **Recaredo**, Captain of the Order of the Companion. Nyx notes the name mentally.
3. At the entrance, Ontharr looks at Nuberroca with plain disappointment — he expected better — turns and starts to leave, telling them the barge for tomorrow midday is arranged.
4. Nuberroca catches him on the way out. He wipes blood from himself, drops it deliberately on the stones between them and says: is this not brutality *to you*? — it's clear I need to calibrate mine better. Ontharr answers that there is no place in the world with worse brutalities than the remotest villages; Nuberroca allows he has restrained himself, and Ontharr knows it. Ontharr walks away.
5. Sinsong comes up to Nuberroca and lays a hand on his shoulder, murmuring *no killing, no killing, remember?*. As the touch lands, Nuberroca sees the dwarf's bald head glow, feels the wound knit, and lifts Sinsong bodily off his feet with a grin: *those were the words I needed*.
6. Nuberroca announces that this repulsive city does not deserve any more of their time, but he is curious about the sun — evil does not rest. Amidamaru, Mialee and Sinsong argue for finding a boat before losing the day.
7. Before they go, Nuberroca presses Amidamaru — are you sure no one is chasing you?. Amidamaru insists he doesn't know why the bandits singled him out; if the appearance is not his own, it wasn't the elf face they were after. Nyx presses: the child touched him and looked startled — that was what marked him. Amidamaru allows there was rough living in **Westgate** but says no law and no bandit is on his trail there. Nyx accepts the answer for now; Sinsong mutters he doesn't believe a word of it.

7 – The wrong boat

~14:30, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. At the port they find a merchant barge finishing its load. About halfway across the docks Amidamaru turns and heads back to the inn; he is done with the day and needs sleep to have his magic back.
2. Nyx walks up first and asks whether the barge is taking travellers — the answer is yes, a hundred silver per hundred miles of route, so twelve gold each for the six of them, rounded to seventy-five gold in the captain's favour.
3. Nyx offers services in exchange: Sinsong as a healer, Nuberroca for guard-work and cargo, herself for the galley. The captain shrugs off the medic — a quiet run — but under Nyx's hard bargaining knocks the fare to sixty gold, then to fifty. They pool the money — Nyx roughs the split at eight-and-change each and drops her share; Nuberroca and Mialee both pay in.
4. During the wait for the barge, Nuberroca hunts down a wise old man in the town — the type of elder who sits in a circle of grey-haired locals and knows the city's stories — and asks about the sun.
5. The elder gives him the version that isn't officially heresy: the second sun appeared when the city was near-lost to a plague of vampires and undead; the Hellriders alone were fighting them and losing ground. When the sun rose in the middle of the night, most of the vampires still in the streets — including the old governor — burned on the spot. The Hellriders finished the rest, the pilgrims flooded in from across the region, and the Order of the Companion was founded around the light.
6. Attributing the sun to any single god is illegal, the elder adds — a rule made after mass pilgrimage arrivals to keep the city off a civil war over gods. Popular tradition ties the sun's coming to **Thavius Kreeg**, the current mayor, because the sun appeared as he was rising in power; officially, though, the sun is called *the gift of Amaunator*, and Amaunator is who most people quietly believe made it.
7. Also during the wait, Nyx buys a fresh quiver of arrows and an off-hand quiver, at about a gold each. Mialee stops to buy sticks of incense for her familiar rituals — ten pieces of gold.
8. When it comes to boarding, the horses Ontharr had told them to keep through to Baldur's Gate become a problem — the barge is loaded past the gunwales and the captain never agreed to horses on the run. Nuberroca offers two of the animals as extra fare; the captain declines. Mialee cuts through it: why do they need horses at all if the boat is supposed to drop them at Baldur's Gate? The party agrees to leave them behind — Mialee proposes handing them back to Leosin — and boards without them.
9. The barge unmoors, the mule-teams brace along the tow-paths, and it begins to move. Within a minute or two the party notices that the direction is wrong — the barge is heading *upstream*, away from Baldur's Gate.
10. *You seriously hired a boat that doesn't go to Baldur's Gate?*, Mialee groans, and Sinsong is already talking about jumping into the water. Sinsong half-proposes hijacking — have him order the captain overboard and take the barge — Amidamaru shuts him down: enough, his ideas never work. They ask for their fare back; the captain won't return it, the cabins are held.
11. They walk off the barge with no refund. The barge, they will learn afterwards, was bound for Scornubel — a hundred miles upstream — while Baldur's Gate is a hundred and fifty and downstream.
12. Mialee walks straight back to Ontharr and asks him — plainly — for the *name* of the barge he had arranged, so they cannot make the same mistake again. Ontharr gives it: **La Sirena de agua dulce**, departing tomorrow around midday.

8 – At the town hall

~17:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Mialee finds the barge at the dock, tells the captain she is one of the passengers due to board tomorrow, and asks to move into her cabin now — she is tired. The captain will not hand over the cabins early, but for five silver a head he will let them sleep on board overnight. Mialee pays; Sinsong and Nyx take the same deal.
2. Nuberroca then plants himself at the town hall door. Two guards in the two-suns emblem — one Companion, one Hellrider — stand at the gate. Nuberroca asks for audience with the mayor to talk about the sun and about the undead plague he faces at home. The guards ask who he is; he lists his credentials — one of the party from Greenest that faced the dragon, an envoy from the far north, and recently admitted to the Order of the Gauntlet, its emblem on his chest. That name gets him a check inside — the mayor is not in.
3. The goliath leaves a message that Nuberroca Quebrantacielos was here inquiring about the sun and a possible alliance against the northern plague. The Hellrider at the gate offers his order's sincere apologies for the party's cause but is plain that the Hellriders' operations reach only the highlands around Elturel; he cannot promise force at long range. The order's method against the undead is faith — no single god required — and Nuberroca strikes him as a man of action, not meditation. Nuberroca thanks him and walks off to the tavern.
4. For the rest of the afternoon, Nuberroca settles at the tavern, pays a couple of copper for a beer, and waits out the hours.

9 – Sirena de agua dulce

~08:00, 3 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Morning of the following day. Nuberroca wakes at eight and walks to the dock; the barge is there, its name matches — *La Sirena de agua dulce*. The tavern kept no breakfast that morning, so the party arrives at the barge on empty stomachs; Nyx pulls out a handful of the berries she prepared the day before and hands them round.
2. Around the midday hour, the barge is loaded to the gunwales; there is barely room to walk on deck, though a passenger can step out for air. The captain sets expectations: two to three days downriver, no intermediate stops, and the autumn rains should carry them fast. The barge unmoors.
3. Amidamaru does not come up on deck — hidden away in his cabin, coming out only for meals, then in an elf's shape. Their contact in Baldur's Gate, per Ontharr, is a merchant named **Ackyn Selebon**, who works in the north of the city — the party will need to make their own approach to him after landing.
4. The barge slips into the current; the mule-teams take the tow-paths on both banks. A full day of travel passes without event.
5. The mid-river country reads back to them as the day wears on: the south bank is greener, the north bank drier and browner; when the light thins, distant large figures can be sighted moving inland — trolls, in a stretch famously more dangerous than the rest of the river — and occasional mounted patrols pass on the roads to keep the routes secure.

10 – The hippo raid

~14:00, 4 Uktar 1489 DR

1. About six hours into the second day of the trip, they hear a hard knock in the hull. The barge is heavy enough that it does not roll, but a solid thump comes through the boards; a second one follows.
2. On deck the crew are trying to fend off animals — four large forms in the water, coming in on both sides of the barge. Hippopotamuses. Aggressive enough that the hull is already losing wood on one side.
3. The party opens fast. Nyx puts an arrow into the nearest one over the low gunwale; Sinsong lays a drowsing hum across the water and puts another under. Mialee brings up a tiny illusion between the two on the far side — a short, piercing squeal placed right between them — and both wheel around at the sound and swim off. Sinsong then turns to the sleeping one, points, and orders it to run; the word takes and the animal wakes into a flight upstream.
4. Nuberroca picks up his lance and moves down to the barge's rail. A thrust lands on the animal hitting the hull, and the shaft's force puts it onto its back in the water.
5. Before that one can right itself, another hippo climbs the gunwale and charges Nuberroca; he catches it hard as it comes in, but the beast's rush takes a chunk out of him on the way through — and then a soft blue glow rises over the wound and the flesh knits back closed.
6. ***[EPIC]*** With a yell, the barbarian drives a thrust clean through the hippo — no guard, all commitment; the beast falls beaten at the barge's side and rolls once as it dies, tearing off a piece of the plank it had been smashing.
7. Sinsong turns to the deck-climber and orders it to flee; the word takes and it runs, at least for the moment. But another hippo climbs up in short order and clamps its bite on Nyx, almost tearing her apart. Nuberroca answers with the same all-in commitment — the lance goes clean through, and the follow-up puts the hippo flat on the deck.
8. Nuberroca crows: tonight they dine on hippo.
9. Even as the fight runs, the barge is already holed and shipping water in more than one place; Mialee slips a small-repair charm across the worst of the damage as the crew frantically bails around her. Once the last hippo is off, Sinsong turns his own repair magic to the planks and together with Mialee they finish piece by piece; the captain accepts it as good enough to finish the run.

11 – Baldur's Gate

~12:00, 5 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The rest of the second day passes without incident. The following morning the mountain that sits above **Baldur's Gate** rises in the distance; by midday the barge is at the docks.
2. The city is bigger than any of them — save Amidamaru — has seen: a proper port, packed and noisy.
3. Their Baldur's Gate contact, per Ontharr's brief, is at the northern gate — the **Black Dragon Gate**.
4. The captain gives the party a warm hand off the boat, thanks them for the help with the hippos and the repairs, and promises to send word back to both Leosin and Ontharr.
5. Nuberroca stays on the dock to help the crew unload — they are hard-pressed to make time and money back, and his strength is worth a couple of hours — and tells the others to go ahead.